Aquifer Open Study Notes (Profiles)

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This resource has been adapted into multiple languages, including English, Tok Pisin, Arabic (عربي), French (Français), Hindi (हिंदी), Indonesian (Bahasa Indonesia), Portuguese (Português), Russian (Русский), Spanish (Español), Swahili (Kiswahili), and Simplified Chinese (简体中文).

T

Thomas

Thomas was one of the 12 apostles (Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:15; Acts 1:13). He is also known as "the Twin." People remember him most for doubting that Jesus had risen from death.

We do not know how Jesus first met and called Thomas to be his disciple. The Gospel of John is the only source with personal accounts of Thomas. Thomas expressed his willingness to follow Jesus, even if it meant death (John 11:16). He openly told Jesus that he did not understand what he was saying (John 14:5). Thomas was also one of the seven disciples who went back to fishing after the resurrection, when Jesus appeared to them (John 21:2).

When Jesus first appeared to his disciples after his death, Thomas was not there. When Thomas heard the others' report, he did not believe it. He insisted he needed to see the crucifixion marks on the body of Jesus and touch them himself (John 20:19–25). A week later, Jesus appeared to the disciples again and spoke directly to Thomas. He told Thomas to examine the nail and spear marks on his body and challenged him to believe, not doubt (John 20:26–27).

When Thomas saw Jesus alive again, he made one of the most important statements in the New Testament. He acknowledged Jesus as God by saying, "My Lord and my God!" (John 20:28). This moment shows most clearly in John's Gospel that Jesus is divine (God in human form).

Later traditions say Thomas worked as a missionary in the East, including Parthia (according to Eusebius), Persia (according to Jerome), and India (according to the Acts of Thomas). The Mar Thoma Church on India's west coast traces its origins to Thomas's early missionary work. The historical accuracy of these accounts is uncertain.

Some ancient books claim to be written by Thomas or to be about him, but these were written long after he died and are not considered reliable. These include:

- The Acts of Thomas
- The Infancy Gospel of Thomas
- The Epistle to the Apostles
- The Apocalypse of Thomas
- The Book of Thomas the Athlete
- The Gospel of Thomas (a Gnostic collection of the sayings of Jesus)

Passages for Further Study

Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:15; John 11:16; John 14:5; John 20:24–29; John 21:2; Acts 1:13

Timothy

Timothy traveled with Paul for much of Paul's missionary work. He was one of Paul's most loved and trusted helpers. Paul wrote two of his last letters to Timothy. At that time, Timothy was leading the church in Ephesus, near the end of Paul's life.

Timothy had a devout mother and grandmother (2 Timothy 1:5). The Christians in his hometown, Lystra, and nearby Iconium respected him highly. He joined Paul's missionary team during Paul's second journey. Paul mentions prophetic words that confirmed Timothy's selection. Timothy received a special gifting for service through the laying on of hands by the elders and Paul (1 Timothy 1:18; 4:14; 2 Timothy 1:6). To respect the Jews in the area, Paul had Timothy circumcised (Acts 16:1–3). Paul did this so that Timothy would be accepted by the Jewish people they wanted to teach about Jesus.

Over the next fifteen years, Paul sent Timothy on special missions to various churches (Acts 19:22; 1 Corinthians 4:17; 16:10–11; Philippians 2:19–23; 1 Thessalonians 3:1–6; 1 Timothy 1:3; see also Acts 17:14–15; 18:5). Paul included Timothy's name as coauthor in several of his letters (2 Corinthians 1:1; Philippians 1:1; Colossians 1:1; 1 Thessalonians 1:1; 2 Thessalonians 1:1; Philemon 1:1). Paul clearly had a close relationship with Timothy and respected him greatly (see Romans 16:21; 1 Corinthians 4:17; 1 Thessalonians 3:2; 1 Timothy 1:2; 6:11; 2 Timothy 1:2). As Paul neared the end of his life and awaited his sentence in prison, he strongly desired to see Timothy (2 Timothy 1:3–4). Among all Paul's coworkers, Timothy is especially praised for his selfless concern for Jesus and his people (Philippians 2:20–22).

Paul's second letter to Timothy (2 Timothy) was written shortly before Paul was killed. In this letter, he encouraged Timothy to be bold and fearless in sharing the good news about Jesus. He urged Timothy to be willing to suffer for Jesus (2 Timothy 1:8; 2:1–3; 4:1–2, 5). This was a strong message for someone who might have been naturally timid (see 2 Timothy 1:6–7). Timothy himself seems to have become a prisoner later on (Hebrews 13:23).

Timothy was a great example of serving Jesus in humble and unnoticed ways. He devoted himself selflessly and focused on the work of Jesus and his people wherever help was needed. He reminds believers to become strong and effective witnesses for Jesus.

Passages for Further Study

Acts 16:1–3; 17:14–15; 18:5; 19:22; 20:4; Romans 16:21; 1 Corinthians 4:17; 16:10–11; 2 Corinthians 1:1, 19; Philippians 1:1; 2:19–23; Colossians 1:1; 1 Thessalonians 1:1; 3:2–6; 2 Thessalonians 1:1; 1–2 Timothy; Philemon 1:1; Hebrews 13:23

Titus

Titus was a Gentile (non-Jewish person) who became a follower of Jesus. He served as one of Paul's trusted helpers. Paul wrote one of his last letters to Titus while Titus was helping to strengthen the church in Crete. Titus shows us how the good news about Jesus changed the lives of non-Jewish people. Many of them, like Titus, believed so strongly in this message that they left their homes to help Paul share the good news about Jesus with others.

We do not know anything about Titus's background or conversion. His name is not mentioned in Acts. We first hear of him as a non-Jewish believer who went with Paul and Barnabas to Jerusalem (Galatians 2:1). Importantly, Paul emphasized that Titus was not forced to be circumcised (Galatians 2:3).

Later, as a trusted member of Paul's team, Titus went on special assignments. Paul sent him to Corinth to handle a difficult situation, likely carrying the demanding letter mentioned in 2 Corinthians 2:4, 9; 7:8–9. This task needed someone who could be both gentle and strong as a leader. Titus seemed to have a stronger personality than Timothy (see 1 Corinthians 16:10–11; 2 Corinthians 7:13–15; 2 Timothy 1:6–7).

Titus returned to Paul with good news (2 Corinthians 7:6–7, 13–15). After that, Paul sent him back to Corinth with the letter we call 2 Corinthians. This letter encouraged the believers to finish their fundraising for the poor believers in Jerusalem. Titus eagerly accepted this task because he loved the Christians in Corinth (2 Corinthians 7:15; 8:6, 16–17). Paul described him as a person of integrity and similar to Paul himself (2 Corinthians 8:23; 12:18).

A few years later, after Paul's first trial in Rome and his release, he left Titus on the island of Crete to strengthen the church. While Titus was there, Paul wrote a letter to him. In the letter, Paul gave advice on choosing church leaders and encouraged Titus to teach and show godly behavior. Paul then asked Titus to meet him at Nicopolis (in Achaia), where Paul planned to spend the winter (Titus 3:12). Later, shortly before Paul was executed in Rome, he wrote that Titus had gone to Dalmatia (along the Adriatic coast, northwest of modern-day Greece), likely for ministry work there (2 Timothy 4:10).

The church historian Eusebius mentions an early tradition that Titus settled on Crete and served as bishop there until he was very old (Eusebius, Church History 3.4.6).

Passages for Further Study

2 Corinthians 2:13; 7:6, 13–14; 8:6, 16–17, 23; 12:18; Galatians 2:1, 3; 2 Timothy 4:10; Titus 1:4; 2:1